

ORIGINAL ARTICLE

Travel to allies or adversaries? A compositional analysis of U.S. diplomatic visits

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Abstract

Objective: When and why do U.S. leaders visit their allies or adversaries? Much of the literature on diplomatic visits treats each visit as an independent observation. In this article, we analyze high-level diplomatic visits as compositional data based on the assumption that they are scarce political resources.

Methods: We conduct a compositional analysis of U.S. high-level officials’ diplomatic visits between 1950 and 2010.

Results: We find that U.S. diplomatic visits to its allies are defense-oriented, so leaders spend more time touring them during their security crises to signal reassurance. Additionally, we find that visits to adversaries are motivated by leaders’ domestic political concerns, particularly their high public unpopularity. Visiting a hostile country is a challenging and salient foreign policy task, providing a high-profile opportunity to improve their domestic image and standing. This effect is particularly significant in a divided government, where leaders turn to foreign policy to maximize domestic political impacts amid domestic gridlock.

Conclusion: The findings suggest that U.S. leaders travel to allies and adversaries for distinct strategic purposes. Furthermore, our study suggests that future research on diplomatic visits should use a compositional variable approach to better model the dynamics and competitive nature of travel diplomacy.

When and why do U.S. leaders visit their allies more frequently than their adversaries, or vice versa? In March 2022, U.S. President Joe Biden visited Poland to reassure the country following Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. During the visit, he publicly committed to “defend Poland militarily, as a member of NATO, should Russia attack its soil.”¹ It took him less than a year to return to Poland in February 2023 with a similar but stronger message. This time, he vowed, “Article 5 is a sacred commitment that the United States has made, and it will defend literally every inch of NATO.”² These visits appeared to have been

¹ NBC News. “Takeaways from Biden’s trip to Europe: Unity, reassurance and a memorable gaffe.” <https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/white-house/takeaways-bidens-trip-europe-rcna21718>(accessed February 28, 2023).

² The Guardian. “US will defend’ literally every inch of Nato’, says Biden - video.” <https://www.theguardian.com/world/video/2023/feb/22/us-will-defend-literally-every-inch-of-nato-says-biden-video>(accessed February 28, 2023).

effective in reassuring the partner, as Polish President Duda stated, “(Biden’s visit) strengthens the unity of NATO and makes the country feel that this place is safe and secure.”³

Not only do U.S. high-level officials travel to its military allies, but they also periodically visit their longstanding adversaries. The most notable example is Nixon’s visit to China in 1972 when he flew to Beijing for the first time as president and met with Chinese Communist Party Chairman Mao. Unlike visits to allies, scholars have suggested that Nixon’s trip to China was motivated by domestic political advantage (Colaresi 2004; Schultz 2003, 2005). Indeed, the trip was undertaken at a time when he was domestically unpopular, and it resulted in a substantial increase in his popularity.⁴ These episodes clearly demonstrate that U.S. diplomatic visits are a highly political events with strategic objectives that are meticulously planned by the leader and their staff members.

Political scientists have examined the determinants of U.S. leaders’ diplomatic visits and how domestic politics and strategic considerations shape the leaders’ visit decisions (Cavari and Ables 2019; Lebovic and Saunders 2016; Ostrander and Rider 2019; Potter 2013). The yet unanswered question, however, is the compositional nature of travel diplomacy. A leader’s diplomatic visit is a scarce resource that requires an investment of both time and energy (Lebovic 2018). It also entails a substantial opportunity cost, as the leader could have allocated the resources to other domestic initiatives that are more directly related to the incumbent’s electoral fortunes. Simply put, leaders cannot travel indefinitely. Therefore, the percentage of visits to each country in the U.S. travel diplomacy portfolio is a form of compositional data similar to any variable that sums to a fixed constraint. When a leader increases the proportion of travel to a specific country, this must logically result in a reduction in the number of visits to other countries. We should consider these trade-offs across multiple categories when analyzing diplomatic visits, rather than ignoring the interdependence of diplomatic travel decisions.

According to our knowledge, no research has analyzed diplomatic visits as a compositional variable; rather, each visit has been treated as an independent observation. For instance, political scientists have investigated when U.S. politicians spend the most time traveling abroad and which nations they are most likely to visit (Koliev and Lundgren 2021; Lebovic and Saunders 2016). However, they neglect the possibility that an increase in visiting one component of foreign travel diplomacy will typically be offset by a reduction of visits in other regions. They also ignore the dynamic nature of diplomatic visits, meaning how the proportion of the compositions evolves over time. In this article, we examine the foreign trip portfolio of U.S. leaders as compositional data to understand the trade-offs between multiple categories and how a change in one composition affects the overall dynamics of diplomatic visits. We focus on a specific category of international travel destinations: military allies and adversaries.

We argue that U.S. presidents and secretaries are more likely to visit their military allies when they have recently been engaged in militarized interstate disputes while visiting fewer adversarial countries. The primary purpose of ally visits is to send messages of support and reassurance to allies in times of crisis. They also reduce visits to adversarial countries because such travel may send the wrong signal that they support their adversaries. The U.S. has established defensive pacts with 51 countries around the world, and U.S. leaders often face challenges and responsibilities in managing the American-led global alliance system. As shown in the earlier anecdote, U.S. high-level officials use foreign travel to address threats to the alliance system and reassure their partners.

We also argue that domestic politics influence the likelihood of diplomatic visits to adversaries. In times of unpopularity, political leaders favor risky decisions that could have a significant impact on public opinion, as they need to shake things up in order to retain office (Debs and Goemans 2010). In travel diplomacy, a visit to an adversary is both a challenging task and a high-profile issue for the incumbent (Wood and Peake 1998). It provides them with the opportunity to demonstrate their foreign policy competence and,

³ The White House. “Remarks by President Biden and President Andrzej Duda of Poland Before Expanded Bilateral Meeting.” <https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2022/03/26/remarks-by-president-biden-and-president-andrzej-duda-of-poland-before-expanded-bilateral-meeting/> (accessed February 28, 2023).

⁴ Gallup. “Gallup Vault: Nixon’s China Visit Was a Game Changer.” <https://news.gallup.com/vault/204065/gallup-vault-nixon-china-visit-game-changer.aspx> (accessed April 24, 2023).

consequently, increase their popularity. While there is a certain risk with this strategy as the public reaction could be negative, they can expect to easily improve the campaign if the public and media attention is positive (Thomson 2020). Therefore, leaders who face domestic unpopularity will be more inclined to visit their adversaries in an effort to restore domestic popularity. These effects are substantial, particularly in a divided government where the president's hands are tied in the legislature. Travel diplomacy is a policy arena where even presidents with low political capital can exert influence over decision-making (Potter 2013). When legislative options for domestic agendas are limited, top executives will shift their attention to foreign policy to make domestic political impacts.

Using data on U.S. high-level official visits between 1950 and 2010, we analyze how strategic and domestic factors determine the composition of U.S. foreign visit targets. First, we find that U.S. presidents and secretaries spend more time traveling to their friends when these allies are involved in more conflicts, at the expense of visiting fewer adversaries. Second, we discover that U.S. presidents are more likely to travel to adversarial countries when they are facing dwindling domestic public approval. Moreover, we find that this pattern becomes more evident when the president faces a domestically divided government. Our finding holds up under a variety of empirical specifications.

This study makes two contributions to the literature on diplomatic visits. First, our findings suggest one way to subcategorize the U.S. high-level travel diplomacy portfolio: military allies and adversaries. This allows us to determine when a particular category of countries is visited more frequently. Scholars have shown that both domestic politics and strategic considerations are crucial factors in explaining a leader's foreign destination. In addition to confirming the significance of both variables, our findings show that strategic considerations influence visits to military allies, whereas domestic political motivation is important in visits to adversaries.

Second, our study improves the research design by treating diplomatic visits as a compositional variable. All political leaders have limited resources for foreign travel and must make strategic decisions regarding which countries to visit more frequently and which less frequently. Therefore, diplomatic visits are closely related because these leaders need to decide about where to make sacrifices when allocating additional resources to a particular category. However, prior studies treated foreign travel as an independent event, which is an implausible assumption. Our application of a compositional variable framework enhances our understanding of the dynamics of the entire portfolio of travel diplomacy and the circumstances under which U.S. leaders prioritize visiting allies over adversaries or vice versa.

DIPLOMATIC VISITS IN INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

In international relations literature, a scholarly focus on diplomatic visits has emerged relatively recently. One group of scholars investigated which countries are more likely to attract visits by high-level U.S. officials. They have shown that U.S. presidents and secretaries are more likely to visit countries that are strategically important to the country: those who trade more with the United States, spend more on their military, and are major customers of U.S. military sales (Lebovic 2018; Lebovic and Saunders 2016). The authors reach the conclusion that U.S. diplomatic visits serve a set of priorities based on relatively stable national interests and diplomatic routine. Koliev and Lundgren (2021) examine which states are more likely to be invited to visit the United States. They find similar results showing that strategic importance matters: leaders of countries that trade more with the United States and receive more U.S. military aid are more likely to be invited. Further, the authors discover that the profiles of invitees during and after the Cold War differ significantly, confirming that structural variables have the most significant influence on high-level visits.

Scholars have also shown that domestic political factors influence the U.S. president's travel decisions (Cavari and Ables 2019; Kim 2024; Ostrander and Rider 2019; Potter 2013). Potter (2013) demonstrates that presidents with little political capital, such as those who won the election with a small electoral margin or who faced low public approval, are more likely to use diplomatic visits, which is a less constrained foreign policy than the decision to use military force. Ostrander and Rider (2019) show that U.S. presidents

travel more days when opportunity costs are lower, such as during the last 2 years of the second term, not during election years, and when they lack control of Congress due to a divided government. Cavari and Ables (2019) find consistent results. Their data indicate that U.S. presidents travel to more foreign countries when the government is divided. When presidents' hands are tied in the legislature and they lack sufficient decision-making authority over domestic agendas, they shift their focus to foreign policy, where they are subject to fewer restrictions from Congress.

Another set of scholars has focused on the political impacts that diplomatic visits by leaders of major powers have on the host country. McManus (2018) shows that a visit by a leader of five great powers—the United States, Russia, China, Britain, and France—to smaller countries provides security benefits by signaling an extended deterrent commitment. Moreover, diplomatic visits shape the public opinion of the host country. Malis and Smith (2021) demonstrate that major power visits boost public confidence in the incumbent government, thus enhancing the incumbent's likelihood of remaining in office. Goldsmith, Horiuchi, and Matush (2021) show that high-level visits by nine major powers improve public support for the major powers in the visited country. Lastly, Wang et al. (2023) find that the visit of U.S. Senators to Taiwan bolsters Taiwanese public confidence in the national government's security policy and military capability.

Several studies have examined the economic effects of foreign trips by major power figures. According to Nitsch (2007), diplomatic visits by the heads of state of France, Germany, and the United States result in an increase in exports to the visited countries. Beaulieu, Lian, and Wan (2020) further show that the trade promotion effects of state visits by Chinese leaders remain the most significant 2 years after the trips. Stone, Wang, and Yu (2022) argue that Chinese leadership visits produce signals to state-owned firms where to make foreign direct investments (FDI). Therefore, Chinese outward FDI from state-owned enterprises, but not from private firms, effectively retraces the footprints of the state visits by the Chinese leadership.

Despite the vast literature on the causes and consequences of diplomatic visits, none has treated this variable as compositional data. Instead, prior research has considered each visit an independent decision. In practice, however, leaders must carefully allocate their limited time and resources for international travel, as choosing to visit one country entails skipping visits to other countries. Consequently, we group visit targets based on the target country's security status: military allies and adversaries. Building on the literature showing that both strategic and domestic factors influence the decision of U.S. diplomatic visits, this study examines how each determinant changes the overall profile of visit destinations.

THEORY

Security reassurance and visits to allies

As a global superpower, the United States has numerous military allies around the world. Based on the formal establishment of defense pacts, the United States has 51 allies. For U.S. leaders, reassuring allies of the stability of the U.S.-led alliance system is an important foreign policy objective.⁵ However, in military alliances, especially asymmetric ones, weaker members are unsure of the great power's loyalty to the alliance. They are aware that the great powers may not honor their alliance commitments due to the absence of an enforcing authority in the international system. Scholarly research shows that only 22 percent of alliance commitments were honored in the post-World War II era (Berkemeier and Fuhrmann 2018). This makes it more difficult and crucial for a great power to convince a weaker ally of the alliance's credibility and commitment.

Diplomatic visits are often used by U.S. leaders to reaffirm their commitment to the alliance. The leader's physical presence on an ally's soil sends a message that the United States is committed to the ally's protection and security. During their visits to allies, U.S. leaders express their support and solidarity in the face of

⁵ Foreign Affairs. "America Needs to Reassure Japan and South Korea." <https://www.foreignaffairs.com/japan/america-needs-reassure-japan-and-south-korea> (accessed August 14, 2023).

security challenges. A visit by high-ranking U.S. officials can reassure an ally through verbal commitments, symbolic endorsement as a valuable partner, and deterrent effects (McManus 2018).

We propose that the U.S. president devote more time and energy to reassuring its allies, particularly when they face serious security threats. Allies are aware that alliance treaties are not always upheld. They have a fear of abandonment that the U.S. will not militarily assist them during a security crisis, or at the very least, may not prioritize their region. Failure to reassure its allies could result in mistrust in the U.S. alliance system and instability in the international order. The president of the United States must reassure allies that the country will provide security support in times of security threats.

Several real-world examples illustrate that when visiting allies, U.S. presidents deliver verbal assurances. When President Biden visited Ukraine and Poland in February 2023, ahead of the anniversary of Russia's invasion of Ukraine, he reassured its allies that the United States is dedicated to "standing with Ukraine and the whole NATO alliance" against Russia's invasion. Although Ukraine is not yet a formal U.S. ally, it has sought NATO membership since 2002 and is bordered by four NATO allies. Biden made a surprise trip to Kyiv, the capital of Ukraine, where he met with President Zelenskyy. The U.S. president announced a new \$500 million armament package for Ukraine and pledged to support the country. During a visit to Poland, one of Ukraine's neighbors, Biden reaffirmed the United States' commitment to NATO:

Let there be no doubt, the commitment of the United States to our NATO Alliance and Article 5 is rock solid... And every member of NATO knows it. And Russia knows it as well. An attack against one is an attack against all. It's a sacred oath to defend every inch of NATO territory.⁶

When visiting an ally in East Asia, U.S. presidents also send a message of reassurance and issue a warning to North Korea and China, which they believe contribute to regional insecurity. For example, when Obama visited South Korea in 2009, he "reaffirmed that the commitment of the United States to the defense and security of the Republic of Korea will never waver" in the face of a series of military provocations from North Korea at the time, including the second North Korean nuclear test and the killing of a South Korean tourist on Mount Kumgang by a North Korean soldier.⁷ These examples indicate that U.S. presidents visit their allies during military disputes to convey words of support and reassurance to the host nation.

Domestic popularity, divided government, and visits to adversaries

When are U.S. high-level officials willing to visit their adversaries? Visiting adversaries often symbolizes a transition from an antagonistic to a friendly relationship and the recognition of the opposing country as a dialogue partner. Yet, visiting an enemy also carries international and domestic risks. The leader must accept the possibility that the adversary may exploit their favorable approach (Schultz 2005). It is also extremely costly from a domestic political standpoint, as negotiations with an adversary may result in a domestic backlash if the leader fails to achieve favorable objectives. However, Nixon's trip to China, Obama's visit to Cuba, and the most recent Trump–Kim summit are only a few examples of U.S. presidential travels to meet foreign adversaries.

We argue that domestic political motivations are one of the primary drivers of U.S. diplomatic visits to adversaries. An unpopular president is willing to adopt this costly and risky policy in order to improve their domestic standing (Debs and Goemans 2010). Visits to adversaries have a greater potential to impact public opinion than other types of visits. First, the media pay more attention to visits to adversaries because

⁶ The White House. "Remarks by President Biden Ahead of the One-Year Anniversary of Russia's Brutal and Unprovoked Invasion of Ukraine." <https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefing-room/speeches-remarks/2023/02/21/remarks-by-president-biden-ahead-of-the-one-year-anniversary-of-russias-brutal-and-unprovoked-invasion-of-ukraine/> (accessed March 9, 2023).

⁷ The White House. "Remarks by President Obama and President Park of the Republic of Korea in Joint Press Conference." <https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/2015/10/16/remarks-president-obama-and-president-park-republic-korea-joint-press>. (accessed May 12, 2022).

they are rare and salient political issues that the media have historically covered in greater depth (Wood and Peake 1998). It is also a more intractable foreign policy task. As their geopolitical interests frequently conflict, it is more difficult to obtain favorable outcomes during trips to adversaries than it is during visits to allies, allowing the incumbent to demonstrate competency. The fact that meeting the adversary generates sustained press coverage of the incumbent and is perceived as a difficult task opens up opportunities for the incumbent with poor domestic standing to shake things up and gamble for resurrection if the media attention is positive.

Some may question why political leaders would use foreign policy to influence public opinion, given that the public has little interest in international affairs. Scholars have traditionally argued that Americans pay much less attention to foreign policy issues and that their attention is ill-informed and deteriorates rapidly (Almond 1950; Converse 1964; Holsti 2004; Lippmann 1955; Wittkopf 1990). Recent research has demonstrated, however, that the public responds predictably and prudently to global events (Jentleson 1992; Kertzer 2013; Page and Shapiro 2010). Additionally, the news media can increase public interest in foreign events. The news media have traditionally provided extensive coverage of U.S. relations with their adversarial states, such as the Soviet Union, China, Vietnam, and countries in the Middle East, and the public often turns to the media and follows their coverage (Groeling and Baum 2008).

Nixon's trip to China on February 21, 1972, is a good anecdotal example. It was the first visit by a U.S. president to China and opened diplomatic relations between the two countries. At the beginning of January 1971, Nixon's domestic approval rating was 49 percent, one of the lowest points of his presidency.⁸ During the trip, two-thirds of Americans believed the trip was successful, with 68 percent of people predicting that it would be effective in promoting world peace. As a consequence, on March 5, immediately following the visit, his domestic approval rating rose to 56 percent.

One might also ask why political leaders would take domestic popularity so seriously. In democracies, leaders view their popularity as a political asset because it directly affects the incumbent leader's chance to remain in office (Potter 2013; Tomz 2007). Competence in foreign policy is one of the determinants of a leader's overall domestic popularity, and it can occasionally have a substantial effect on the outcome of national elections (Aldrich et al. 2006; Aldrich, Sullivan, and Borgida 1989; Gelpi, Reifler, and Feaver 2007). Moreover, the president's high domestic popularity can increase his or her control over the legislature, as members of the president's party are more likely to win legislative elections if the president is popular (Gronke, Koch, and Wilson 2003). It is why "popularity is a major political resource, possibly the president's single most important base of power" (Gronke, Koch, and Wilson 2003). Thus, democratic leaders have good motivation to see disapproval as a political liability and to do whatever they can to improve their public reputation.

In addition, we argue that domestic political contexts determine whether a president focuses on foreign policy to increase his popularity. Under a divided government, in which the president's party lacks control of Congress, the president is likely to face domestic gridlock. Presidents have limited discretion to pursue domestic initiatives, such as economic and social programs because members of the opposing party are likely to stymie any domestic policy that conflicts with their preferences. In this scenario, presidents' domestic policy options are limited and they will seek to boost their popularity through foreign policy, an area over which they have complete control. Therefore, when presidents are constrained domestically because their hands are tied by the legislative branch, they have a greater incentive to employ foreign policy to boost their domestic popularity.

In contrast, a uniform government makes it easier for presidents to push initiatives through the legislature and become more confident that they will not be vetoed (Canes-Wrone and De Marchi 2002). Stable legislative support allows the president to enact critical domestic initiatives consistent with the interests of his core constituency. There are fewer incentives for presidents to travel abroad to appeal to domestic audiences because they can implement policies that are more directly linked to domestic popularity. Foreign policy can be more dangerous due to the higher opportunity costs associated with not investing more time

⁸ Gallup. "Gallup Vault: Nixon's China Visit Was a Game Changer." <https://news.gallup.com/vault/204065/gallup-vault-nixon-china-visit-game-changer.aspx> (accessed August 14, 2023).

and resources in domestic initiatives when they have the ability to do so. The general public will be dissatisfied if the leader fails to fulfill his or her responsibilities by prioritizing less important policies. Therefore, when domestic political conditions are stable, presidents will prefer to limit their international travel and focus on their domestic agenda, as this is a more effective strategy for gaining domestic popularity.

Hypotheses

In summary, we expect that U.S. presidents and secretaries will visit their military allies more frequently when these allies have experienced recent militarized interstate conflicts in order to provide reassurance and a message of support.

Theorem 1. *U.S. presidents and state secretaries are more likely to visit military allies when allies experience more militarized disputes.*

We expect that U.S. presidents and secretaries will visit their adversaries more frequently when they are unpopular at home. We also anticipate that this negative relationship between domestic popularity and visits to adversaries will only be significant when the government is divided. When leaders' hands are tied at the legislative branch, they will turn their policy efforts toward foreign policy, where they are less constrained to make decisions and can prove their competence. In contrast, under uniform governments, foreign policy decisions will not be affected by their domestic popularity, as they are capable of pursuing other domestic policies, such as economic or social issues, that are more effective in improving their domestic standings. This yields the following hypothesis:

Theorem 2. *U.S. presidents and secretaries are more likely to visit adversaries when their domestic popularity is low, and the effect is significant only when the government is divided.*

DATA AND MEASUREMENTS

We test our theoretical claims using the data on U.S. high-level visits from 1950 to 2010. The Office of Historian at the U.S. Department of State provides a record of the visits of U.S. presidents and secretaries, including information about travel dates, destination countries, and remarks.⁹ By web-scraping the records, we construct an original data set about the U.S. president's and secretary's foreign visits.¹⁰

To explore the dynamics of U.S. leaders' foreign visit portfolios, we transformed the data into a yearly compositional structure. First, we classify destination countries into three categories: allies, adversaries, and other countries. We coded an ally based on whether the country shares a defensive alliance with the United States in a given year using The Alliance Treaty Obligations and Provisions (ATOP) data (Leeds et al. 2002). Based on Diehl, Goertz, and Gallegos (2021), we categorized a country as an adversary if it had a severe or lesser adversarial dyadic relationship with the United States in a given year. We coded as "other" those countries that are neither allies nor adversaries. Note that our categorization is on a yearly basis, so some countries may belong to different categorizations depending on the period of interest. For example, the Soviet Union (or Russia) is coded as "other" between 1990 and 1992 and as an adversary during other time periods.

Second, we excluded from the sample high-level officials' foreign travels that were not for diplomatic purposes, such as refueling, overnight stops, private vacations, fishing trips, and the awarding of honorary degrees from Oxford. For secretaries' visits, we also dropped cases in which they accompanied the president, and only considered their independent travels. Then, we restructure the data set into a compositional

⁹ See <https://history.state.gov/>

¹⁰ Refer to online Appendix Section A for the details on web-scraping.

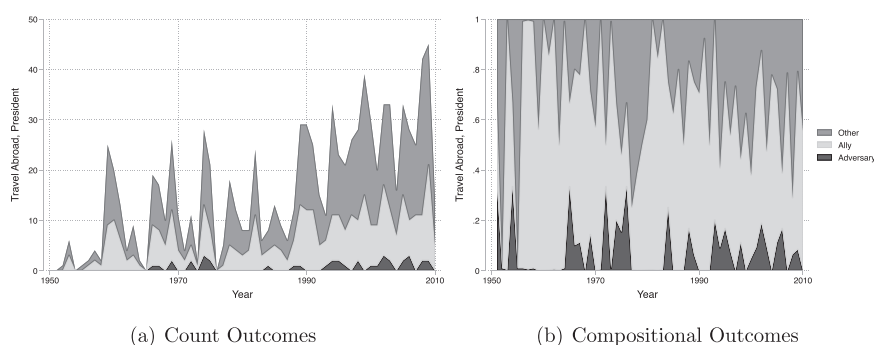


FIGURE 1 The U.S. presidential portfolios of foreign visits from 1950 to 2010.

format, indicating the percentages of visits to allies, adversaries, and “other” countries to the total for that year.

Figure 1 describes the trend of presidential portfolios of foreign visits from 1950 to 2010. Figure 1a,b represents the proportions of each type of visit to the total in absolute and relative terms, respectively. Several factors are noteworthy. First, the total number of presidential visits has been on an increasing trend. This trend seems plausible when we consider the development of transportation and technology over time, which made it much easier for leaders to travel. Second, presidential visits to adversaries are a rare event throughout all periods of interest. Third, in the post-Cold War era, the share of visits to “other” countries has consistently increased. The same patterns hold for the visit portfolios of the secretary. The secretary’s visits are more voluminous than those of the president in absolute terms, resulting in less fluctuation in relative terms. Refer to the online Appendix for the secretary’s foreign visit portfolios.

We include a variable that measures the total number of military disputes that the United States’ allies experienced in a given year using the updated version of the Correlates of War’s Militarized Interstate Dispute (MID) data set by Gibler, Miller, and Little (2016). There are four levels of MID hostility: (1) the threat to use force, (2) the display of force, (3) the use of force, and (4) war. Our main coding rule for the independent variable only considers cases 3 and 4, in which actual force was used. As a robustness check, we replicated our analysis using an alternate measure that counts all disputes regardless of their hostility level. Others may argue that a leader’s foreign policy decisions are determined not only by the events of the current year but also by conflicts from the recent past. In order to address this concern, we replicated the analysis using conflict records from the past 3 years. Based on our theoretical claims, we expect that the variable of allies’ military disputes will significantly increase the proportion of ally visits in the travel diplomacy portfolio.

To measure our second independent variable, domestic popularity, we use the data on presidential approval ratings from Gallup.¹¹ Gallup conducts monthly polls in which respondents are asked whether they approve or disapprove of the president’s job performance. For the main analysis, we use the yearly average of presidential disapproval. We also include data about the status of a divided government: If the presidency and the House of Representatives are controlled by different political parties, assign the value 1; otherwise, assign the value 0. As the House is responsible for all government spending decisions, this variable is most relevant for determining whether the president’s political assets for pursuing domestic policies are constrained. We confirmed the robustness of our findings using different measures, including a divided government between the Presidency and the Senate and a quarterly structure.

¹¹ See <https://news.gallup.com/interactives/185273/presidential-job-approval-center.aspx>. We chose the Gallup public poll data over other sources due to its consistency and comprehensive coverage in measuring presidential approval. It has been common for multiple national polls to ask about the public’s sentiment toward the President’s performance since the 2000s, but Gallup is the only source that has consistently asked the same question since the beginning of the scientific opinion polling era, articulated as follows: “Do you approve or disapprove of the way [President name] is handling his job as President?”

To test our theoretical claims, we include the interaction term between domestic popularity and a divided government. As we argue that the effects of domestic popularity on high-level visits are conditional on a divided government, we expect to find statistical significance only for the interaction term and not for domestic popularity alone. In a uniform government, the president can increase his or her popularity by adopting domestic policies with the support of the legislature. However, if the president's hands are tied in the legislature, she or he will tour foreign adversaries in an effort to achieve a domestic political breakthrough. Therefore, we expect the interaction term to significantly increase the share of visiting adversaries in the overall composition.

To rule out alternative explanations for our findings, we include the following control variables in our statistical analysis: First, we control for the number of conflicts experienced by the United States. The strategic condition of U.S. national security may affect the travel diplomacy decisions of high-level U.S. officials. This variable counts all militarized disputes in a given year, regardless of their level of hostility. Second, we include a post-Cold War dummy variable, which is coded as 1 if the Cold War has ended and 0 otherwise. As time trends in high-level visit portfolios show (Figure 1), the importance of visiting and reassuring allies may have diminished in U.S. foreign policy since the end of the Cold War. Third, we include an economic variable, unemployment rates, in the analysis. Considering the effects of diplomatic visits on international trade, U.S. leaders may be motivated to travel abroad and boost the economy during downturns. Since we expect that foreign policy incentives will be stronger when leaders' hands are tied in domestic politics, we also interact this variable with a divided government. Lastly, we control for the potential confounding variable of incumbent partisanship, which is designated as 1 if the president is a Democrat. Presidential partisanship is not only one of the determinants of a divided government, but it can also shape diplomatic priorities. Summary statistics for the variables are presented in online Appendix Section B.

DYNAMIC SPECIFICATION AND COMPOSITIONAL ANALYSIS

Our study employs a dynamic compositional analysis to account for the competitive nature and dynamics in U.S. travel diplomacy (Philips, Rutherford, and Whitten 2016). As with most political and policymaking processes, leaders' decisions regarding foreign travel involve strategic trade-offs across multiple categories because their resources, particularly their time, are limited. Their decisions to prioritize one category of countries must be counterbalanced by a reduction in travel to other categories of states. This compositional nature implies that each visit decision is not made in isolation from the others so that the stochastic component of one decision can affect the other. By incorporating the interdependence of visit decisions, we can avoid biased estimates of the variables of interest.

A compositional analysis provides a more nuanced understanding of strategic decisions compared to alternatives. Count outcome analysis, for instance, can only reveal whether an ally's engagement in militarized disputes increases the total number of U.S. leaders' visits to the allied country. By contrast, using compositional outcome analysis, we can also determine if the increase in ally visits changes the relative frequency of visits to adversaries or "other" countries.

The dynamic compositional analysis framework estimates seemingly unrelated regression with transformed log ratios of one component to the baseline component as dependent variables (Philips, Rutherford, and Whitten 2016). This approach enables researchers to examine how a change in one part is associated with changes in the overall composition. The log-ratio transformation has two significant advantages in compositional outcome analysis. First, it avoids the unrealistic assumption that the changes in each composition are independent of those in the other compositions. Second, it unbounds the series from the compositional space ranging from zero to one to the unconstrained real plane (Aitchison 1986; Katz and King 1999).

Mathematically, the model can be represented as follows:

$$s_{it} = \ln \frac{J_{it}}{J_{1t}}, \quad \forall i \neq 1,$$

where y_{it} is the percentage of component i in the whole composition at time t , y_{1t} refers to the percentage of the baseline component 1 at time t , and s_{it} the log ratio of component i to the baseline component at time t . Note that before calculating the respective percentages, we added the value of 0.01 to the visit counts for all components to prevent the log values from being diverged to negative infinity by observations with a value of 0.

The model then estimates seemingly unrelated regression (SUR) with the transformed log ratios as the dependent variable, represented as

$$s_{it} = \beta_{0i} + \alpha_i s_{it-1} + \beta_i' \mathbf{X}_t + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where α_i is the effect of the lagged dependent variable, $\mathbf{X}_t$ is a vector of independent variables values at time t , β_i is a vector of short-run effects, and ε_{it} is a matrix of error terms that may be correlated across the $I - 1$ equations. The long-run effects can be calculated as $\frac{\beta}{1-\alpha}$.

As the SUR allows the residuals to be correlated across all equations (Tomz, Tucker, and Wittenberg 2002), the dynamic compositional analysis framework explores how a change in one composition is associated with changes in other compositions. In this way, we explore the dynamics of U.S. high-level visits.

Addressing potential temporal dependencies in U.S. high-level visits is crucial. First of all, we included a lag of the dependent variable in the model. The yearly plan may be based on last year's foreign visits. The lagged dependent variable helps to account for temporal dependence when constructing high-level visit portfolios. Furthermore, we also include cross-actor lagged dependent variables in the estimations. For instance, we include not only the lagged log ratio of presidential visits but also the lagged log ratios of secretarial visits in the estimations of presidential visits. This is because the secretary can participate in the planning of a presidential visit. Third, we used a lagged term for presidential disapproval. While leaders must respond urgently in militarized disputes, consequential diplomacy such as visiting adversaries requires meticulous planning with more time.

In line with best practices, we carried out an array of unit root and stationarity tests. The unemployment variable was identified as a random walk with a trend, while all other variables—including log ratios of both presidential and secretary's compositional variables (s_{it}) and key independent variables (namely, presidential disapproval, U.S. militarized disputes, and U.S. allies' severe militarized disputes)—were classified as stationary. We then differenced the unemployment variable to achieve stationarity. It is worth noting that certain variables, such as the log ratio of presidential visits to adversary countries relative to ally countries, the log ratio of presidential visits to adversary countries relative to other countries, presidential disapproval, and U.S. militarized disputes, exhibited stationarity around a trend. To mitigate potential spurious regression outcomes, we incorporated a trend variable on the right-hand side of the regression equations. Additionally, we factored in the difference in the total count of visit outcomes, ensuring we controlled for the relationship between absolute and relative shifts in visit portfolios.

Lastly, we adopted a systematic approach to our dynamic specification. Drawing upon the practices of Linn and Webb (2020), we initiated with a general model, incorporating up to three lags of the dependent variable and two lags of the independent variables. Subsequently, we refined our approach to arrive at a more parsimonious model. Through iterative testing using serial correlation diagnostics and information criteria, we ensured that the parsimonious model displayed no serial correlation among the error terms and achieved an optimal balance between model complexity and fit.

MAIN FINDINGS

Table 1 presents the regression results from the compositional outcome analysis for presidential visits. The first column employs the log ratio of visits to ally countries relative to those to adversary countries as the dependent variable. In contrast, the second column utilizes the log ratio of visits to other

TABLE 1 Compositional outcome analysis for presidential visits.

	Presidential visits	
	(1)	(2)
	ln $\frac{\text{Ally}}{\text{Adversary}}$	ln $\frac{\text{Other}}{\text{Adversary}}$
s_{t-1}	−0.117 (0.091)	−0.276** (0.107)
U.S. Disputes _{<i>t</i>}	0.368* (0.178)	0.193 (0.210)
Allies' Disputes _{<i>t</i>}	0.168* (0.084)	0.203* (0.100)
Divided Government _{<i>t</i>}	4.508** (1.556)	3.165 (1.868)
Unpopularity _{<i>t-1</i>}	−0.008 (0.029)	−0.052 (0.035)
Δ Unemployment _{<i>t</i>}	−0.413 (0.396)	−0.078 (0.472)
Divided Government _{<i>t</i>}	−0.121**	−0.081
× Unpopularity _{<i>t-1</i>}	(0.041)	(0.049)
Divided Government _{<i>t</i>}	1.393* (0.542)	0.996 (0.650)
× Δ Unemployment _{<i>t</i>}		
Post Cold War _{<i>t</i>}	−2.799** (1.086)	−4.330** (1.326)
Presidential Partisanship _{<i>t</i>}	1.064 (0.636)	2.062** (0.761)
Δ Presidential Visits _{<i>t</i>}	−0.068 (0.037)	−0.003 (0.045)
Trend	0.124*** (0.037)	0.211*** (0.045)
Constant	−0.712 (1.415)	−1.036 (1.677)
Secretary's s_{t-1}	Yes	Yes
R^2	0.589	0.468
N	51	51

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

countries relative to adversary countries. Both columns use visits to adversary countries as the baseline category.

The regression results support our theoretical claims. First, consistent with our expectations, the variable representing allies' disputes is statistically significant in both columns at the 95 percent confidence level. This indicates that in response to militarized disputes among allies, U.S. presidents are less likely to prioritize visits to adversary countries over visits to allies or other nations (Hypothesis 1). Second, while the lagged unpopularity variable is estimated as statistically insignificant, its interaction with the divided government has a significant negative impact on the ratio of visits to ally versus adversary countries at the

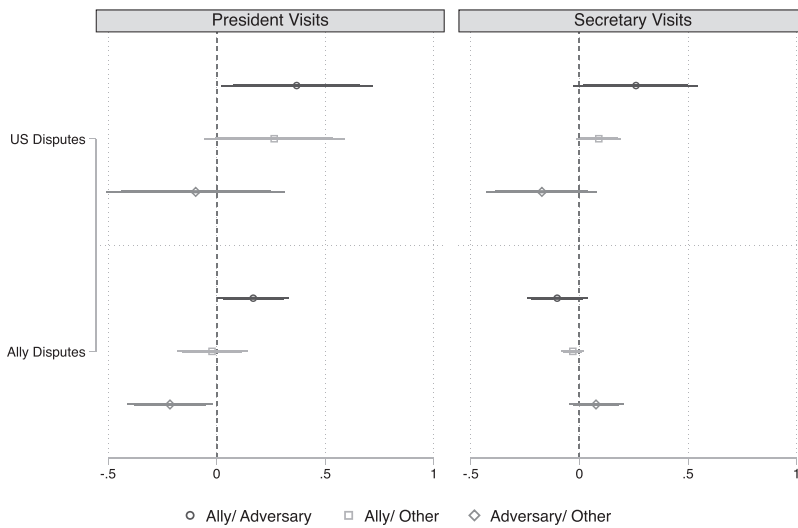


FIGURE 2 Coefficient plots of United States and ally disputes on U.S. diplomatic visits.

95 percent confidence level. This aligns with our expectations, suggesting that U.S. presidents in a divided government are more likely to visit adversary nations if their domestic popularity is low, particularly at the cost of visits to ally countries (Hypothesis 2).

Among the other notable findings, U.S. militarized disputes have a significant positive impact on the ratio of presidential visits to allies compared to adversaries. Like presidential unpopularity, the domestic economy, specifically the unemployment rate, is statistically significant only when interacting with a divided government. Presidents from the Democratic Party are more likely to prioritize visits to other countries over visits to adversary countries compared to administrations led by Republicans. Additionally, both the post-Cold War dummy and trend variables have significant effects, but they operate in opposite directions. However, interpreting the coefficient estimates can be challenging due to our use of the log ratios as the dependent variable. Therefore, we graphically take a closer look at the results by examining the significance of the interaction terms as well as assessing the short- and long-term impacts for each composition below.¹²

In Figure 2, we present parameter estimates of militarized disputes on the log ratios of U.S. high-level visits. The left panel represents the impacts on presidential visits, while the panel on the right depicts the effects on secretarial visits. The panels above represent the effects of militarized disputes involving the United States, while the panels below show the effects of militarized disputes involving allies. Each estimate comes from different regressions using each log ratio as the dependent variable; the point estimates in the shapes of a circle, square, and diamond represent the estimates on the log ratios of visits to allies relative to visits to adversaries, visits to allies relative to visits to others, and visits to adversaries relative to visits to others, respectively.¹³ The thicker and narrower lines indicate 90 percent and 95 percent confidence intervals of estimates, respectively. The confidence interval that has not crossed over zero (dashed lines) indicates that the parameter estimate is statistically different from zero. For instance, if the narrower line of the circle-shaped estimate in the left-upper panel does not cross the dashed line, it indicates that the effect of militarized disputes involving the United States is statistically significant, increasing the log ratio of presidential visits to allies relative to visits to adversaries at the 95 percent confidence level. In other words, the president of the United States pays relatively more visits to allied countries and fewer visits to adversaries in response to disputes involving the country.

¹² The regression table for the secretarial visits is included in online Appendix Section D.

¹³ Note that by “visits to allies,” we mean visits to all allied countries in a given year, not just those allies currently engaged in militarized disputes.

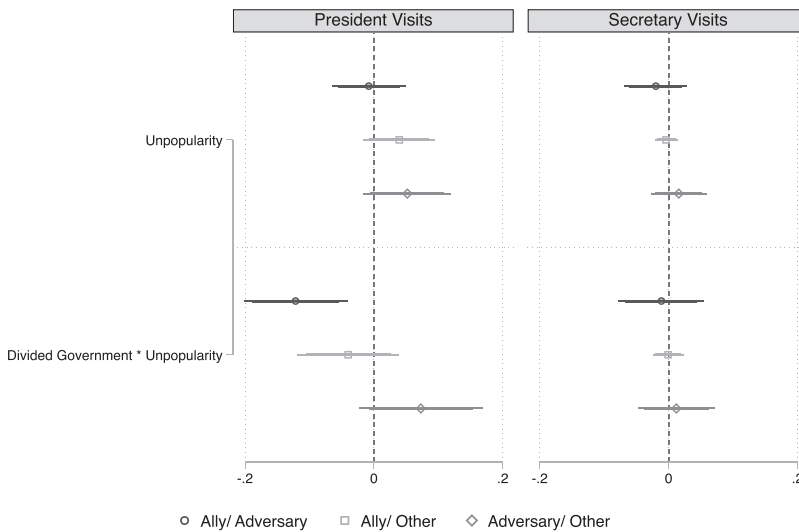


FIGURE 3 Coefficient plots of presidential unpopularity and divided government on U.S. diplomatic visits.

We anticipate that U.S. high-level officials will tour their allies more frequently in response to a greater number of militarized disputes involving their allies. The results support our theoretical claims about presidents. When the U.S. allies are involved in more militarized disputes, presidents visit more allies (panels below in Figure 2). We also find that presidential visits to adversaries become significantly deprioritized relative to visits to allies and other countries. However, we do not find statistically significant effects on secretary visits. The same pattern applies to the results of militarized disputes involving the United States. Presidents respond to their own military conflicts by visiting more allies and fewer adversaries, but the secretary's foreign visit portfolio is not significantly influenced by the country's military disputes. Overall, it implies that the presidential visit is a symbolic event that can reassure allies of their commitment to extended deterrence and security; therefore, only presidents respond to international conflict conditions by visiting more allies and refraining from visiting adversaries so as not to send mixed signals but not secretaries.

In Figure 3, we present the estimated results for domestic political variables. The panels above describe the estimated coefficients of presidential unpopularity, while the panels below describe the estimated coefficients of the interaction term between unpopularity and a divided government. We hypothesize the conditional effects of domestic unpopularity on high-level foreign visits. We argue that domestic unpopularity influences visits to adversaries only under the condition of a divided government. We find statistically significant effects of the interaction between unpopularity and a divided government on presidential visits but do not find the significance of unpopularity alone.

We also find that the interactive effect is not substantial for secretarial visits. There are a number of possible explanations for the null findings regarding secretary visits to adversaries. One possible explanation is that public opinion has no effect on secretarial visits. Existing research indicates that secretarial visits tend to precede those of presidents, suggesting that their primary duty when visiting foreign countries consists of administrative responsibilities, such as organizing and coordinating, prior to the visit of the president. Another possibility is that political elites are aware that only presidents can influence public opinion, so they do not use secretarial visits to improve their domestic standing.

Based on the estimates derived from the main model, we simulated a hypothetical scenario to gain a better understanding of the significant effects. This simulation aims to showcase how domestic unpopularity would shape the composition of presidential visits in the short and long run. The baseline compositions were calculated using the parameter estimates, sample-mean values of continuous variables, and zero values of dummy variables included in the estimated model. We gave a hypothetical shock by increasing the

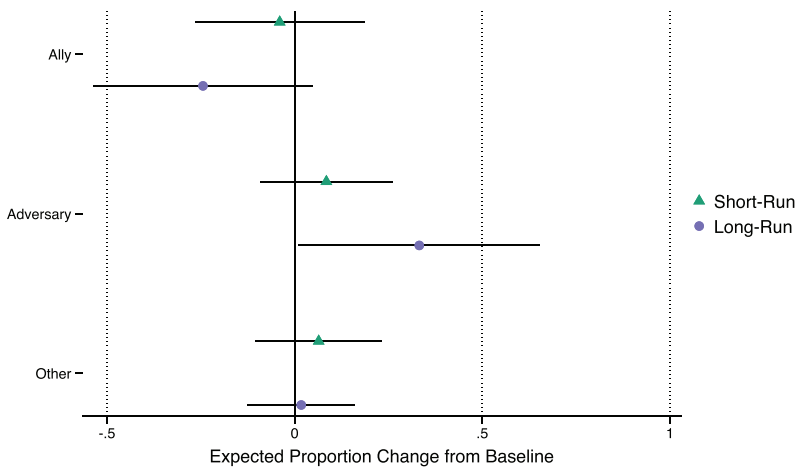


FIGURE 4 Simulated results of short- and long-run effects of a one standard-deviation increase in presidential unpopularity under the condition of a divided government.

value of presidential unpopularity by one standard deviation. In addition, we input the value 1 to the variable representing a divided government for all simulations. To examine how the expected proportions would evolve over time, we ran 1000 simulations using the Stata package of Clarify (Tomz, Whittenberg, and King 2003). The confidence intervals reflect the 90 percent distribution of the simulated results. We use the 90 percent confidence level to test our directional hypotheses.

In Figure 4, we present the simulated effects of domestic unpopularity on the composition of presidential visits under a divided government. The point estimates represent the expected proportional change caused by a one standard deviation increase in presidential disapproval. The green triangles and purple circles demonstrate the short- and long-run effects, respectively. The results show that when the government is divided, presidents visit more adversaries at the expense of visiting allies in response to an increase in domestic popularity. As expected, we do not find significant proportional changes under the condition of a uniform government (see online Appendix Section E for detailed results).

In addition, given that we modeled the effects of unpopularity on visit portfolios with a time lag, the conditional effects of unpopularity are expected to be long term and do not manifest in the same year as a change in unpopularity. In response to a one standard deviation increase in presidential unpopularity, we anticipate that presidents will increase the proportion of visiting adversaries by 35 percent, translating to an additional 2.1 visits.¹⁴ This increase is expected to start in the year following the shock, with the long-term effects becoming fully apparent 3 years postshock. The positive effects of the unpopularity on visiting adversaries are particularly interesting given that the decision is negatively affected by other factors such as increasing militarized disputes or domestic economic downturns. While it is uncommon for all other variables to remain constant over extended periods, our findings offer valuable insight: presidents may be compelled to make unusual foreign policy decisions—visiting more adversaries—when their domestic popularity plummets and their hands are tied to domestic politics, in an effort to achieve a political breakthrough.

A number of findings are noteworthy from the estimates of control variables in the main model. First, the association between the economy and high-level foreign visits is more complicated than the relationship between domestic popularity and visits. In a uniform government, unemployment has little effect on presidential visits but has a significant effect on secretary visits. In response to an increase in unemployment, the secretary travels to significantly fewer adversaries and spends more time visiting allies and

¹⁴ The calculation is based on the average total number of presidential visits for the period of consideration. The annual average of presidential visits is 6, which breaks down to 2.9 ally visits, 0.4 adversary visits, and 2.7 visits to other countries.

“other” countries. Yet, this pattern is reversed when the government is divided, and the share of the secretary’s visits to allies is decreased by increasing unemployment. By contrast, the president travels to more allied countries at the expense of visiting adversaries in response to the economic downturn in a divided government. The results imply that in an economic downturn, visits to allies become prioritized to boost international trade or economic aid, but under a divided government, the president travels instead of the secretary in order to send a strong signal not only to the destination countries but also to domestic voters.

Other control variables are also estimated to have significant effects on presidential visits. First, the post-Cold War dummy variable significantly increases the presidential share of visiting adversaries at the expense of travels to allies and others. It suggests that the end of the Cold War lowered the bar for visiting adversarial countries. Second, Democratic presidents prioritize travel to third-party countries over visits to allies and adversaries. Third, the variable of a divided government significantly increases the share of visits to adversaries over others. In contrast to presidential visits, these explanatory variables are estimated to have statistically insignificant effects on secretary visits at the 95 percent confidence level. The results imply that secretaries follow a predetermined schedule rather than being responsive to external issues. The coefficient estimates are presented in online Appendix Section G.

Count outcome analysis

We also present the results of the count outcome analysis in online Appendix Section H. We regress each count of foreign visits on explanatory variables and employ the SUR to allow correlation in error terms across all equations. In comparison to our main findings from compositional analysis, we find both similar and distinct results. We find consistent evidence that militarized disputes involving the United States reduce the number of presidential visits to adversaries. Count outcome results also confirm that an increase in unpopularity in a divided government has a statistically significant positive effect on presidential visits to adversaries. In addition, explanatory variables other than unemployment have a negligible effect on secretary visits, based on the 95 percent confidence level, which is consistent with our main findings.

Nonetheless, the count outcome analysis conceals some useful information. First, we are unable to determine how a change in foreign visit priority corresponds to relative changes in the frequency of visiting other types of countries. For example, it is unclear which visits are prioritized over visits to adversaries in the context of militarized disputes involving the United States. Moreover, we do not find significant effects of militarized disputes involving allies on the number of U.S. high-level foreign visits (only negative effects on visiting adversaries at the 90 percent confidence level). Taken together, the results from count and compositional approaches suggest that the president of the United States responds to allies’ disputes by shifting priorities between visits to allies and adversaries without increasing or decreasing the total number of visits. By using the compositional approach, therefore, we can gain a better understanding of the dynamics in U.S. leaders’ strategic decisions of diplomatic visits.

CONCLUSION

The article introduces a theory regarding the determinants of U.S. diplomatic visits to allies and adversaries. We argue that U.S. high-ranking officials visit military allies more frequently when they are in need of security reassurance. In particular, when allies are involved in more militarized interstate conflicts, U.S. leaders use their physical presence to reassure their partners. In addition, they devote more resources to visiting allies at the expense of reducing their visits to adversaries. We also maintain that domestic politics is the primary motivation for U.S. leaders to visit adversarial states. When confronted with low domestic popularity under a divided government, presidents are willing to visit their adversaries more often. It is a salient and difficult task, so if completed successfully, the leader’s popularity could be restored. During times of uniform government, presidents have a greater ability to implement domestic policy options that can improve their popularity more effectively; therefore, diplomatic visits are not necessary.

The research tests these theoretical expectations using data on U.S. high-level visits from 1950 to 2010. We employ a compositional variable approach to understand the dynamics of diplomatic visit portfolios. We find evidence that supports our hypotheses. When allies are engaged in a greater number of conflicts, U.S. leaders pay more frequent visits to their allies and less frequently to their adversaries. We also find that U.S. presidents are more likely to visit adversaries when their domestic popularity is low and the government is divided. Our empirical results are robust to methodological modifications and alternative measurements.

Our study makes two contributions to the literature on diplomatic visits. As the first quantitative study to use dynamic compositional analysis, we avoid the implausible assumption that diplomatic visits are independent of other visits. Instead, we examine the overall composition of destination portfolios and how a change in one component affects the composition as a whole. The findings also advance our understanding of the determinants of U.S. high-level diplomatic visits. Scholars have shown that both strategic and domestic political factors determine the foreign trips of U.S. leaders, but less is known about the exact context in which each variable matters. Our findings suggest that strategic considerations influence visits to military allies, while domestic politics influence visits to adversarial states. In addition, we find that domestic political motivations only drive diplomatic visits when the president's hands are constrained by the legislature.

Our research implies that using the dynamic compositional framework is crucial when studying diplomatic visits and foreign policy more broadly. Scholars of a compositional variable conventionally have focused on the domestic political variables like party support and political budgeting. However, political leaders' decisions in foreign policy also involve strategic decisions of trade-offs. Particularly in the travel diplomacy, leaders and staff members do not simply add a list of countries to visit. They manage their overall travel portfolios strategically as their foreign policy resources are limited, and they must choose which category of countries to skip before choosing which category of states to visit more often. This study focuses on one categorization of visit targets, namely military allies and adversaries, but there may be additional strategic categorizations. One example is geographical compositions. The United States has vital national interests on multiple continents and should allocate its foreign policy efforts to each region strategically. For instance, when European countries face significant security threats, U.S. leaders may travel to the region more frequently while reducing their time in South America or Asia. This means that countries in these regions may feel an increased level of fear of abandonment. Future research can investigate the dynamics of the other compositions, including geographical, of diplomatic visits.

Our research suggests using a dynamic compositional framework when analyzing diplomatic visits and, more broadly, foreign policy. Scholars of compositional variables have focused primarily on domestic political variables such as party support and political budget allocation. Political leaders' foreign policy decisions also involve strategic considerations and trade-offs. In the realm of travel diplomacy, leaders and their staff must manage their travel portfolios as a whole by making trade-offs due to limited foreign policy resources. Before deciding which category of countries to prioritize, they must decide which category of countries to skip.

Our research centered on a particular classification of visit destinations: military allies and adversaries. However, there may be additional possible strategic categorizations, such as geographical compositions. The United States, with vital national interests on multiple continents, must strategically allocate its foreign policy efforts across regions. For instance, when European countries face increased security threats, U.S. leaders may increase their visits to Europe while reducing their presence in South America or Asia. Consequently, countries in these regions may experience an increase in abandonment fear. Future research could explore the dynamics of these alternative compositional factors, including geographical considerations, within the context of diplomatic visits and foreign policy.

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SUPPORTING INFORMATION

Additional supporting information can be found online in the Supporting Information section at the end of this article.

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